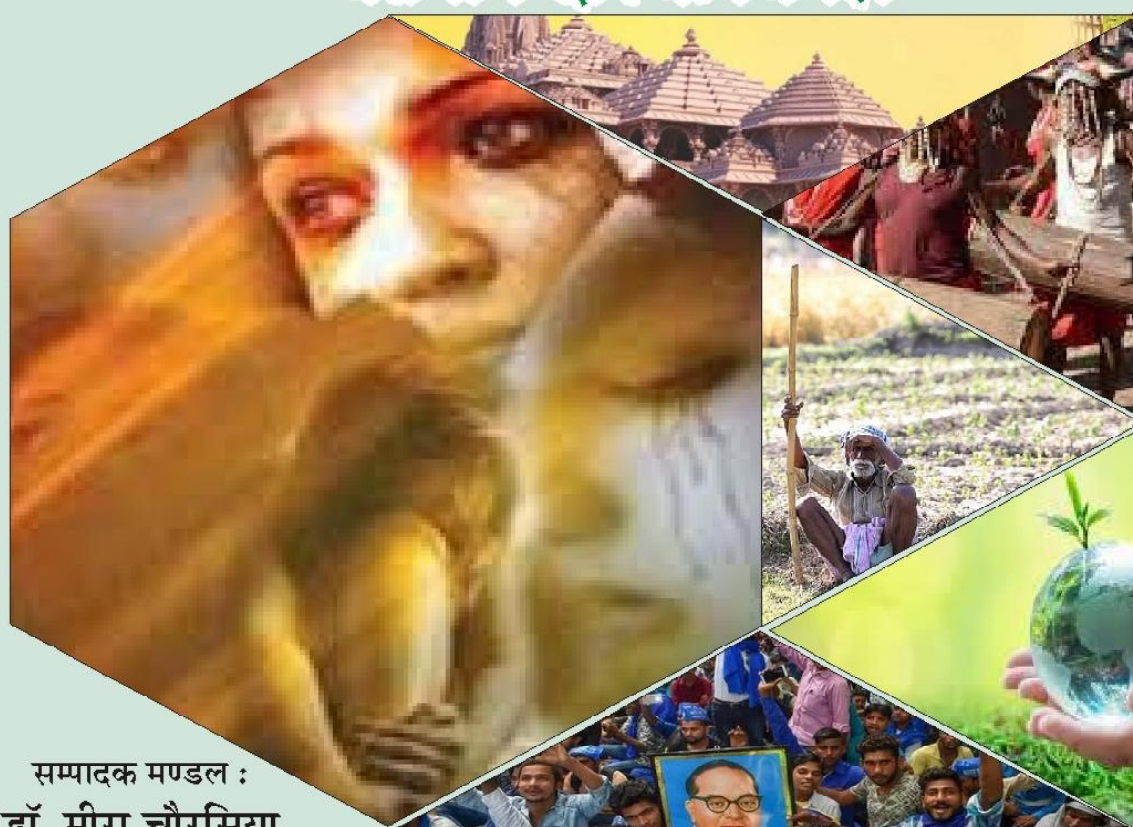


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THE GAZETTE OF INDIA : EXTRAORDINARY

[PART III—SEC. 4]

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शैक्षणिक/ शोध अंक की गणना हेतु विश्वविद्यालय और महाविद्यालय के शिक्षकों के लिए कार्यप्रणाली

(आकलन शिक्षकों द्वारा प्रस्तुत साक्ष्यों पर आधारित होना चाहिए, जैसे: प्रकाशनों की प्रति, परियोजना स्वीकृति पत्र, विश्वविद्यालय द्वारा जारी उपयोग तथा पूर्णता प्रमाण पत्र, पेटेंट दर्ज कराने संबंधी अभिस्वीकृति और स्वीकृति पत्र, विद्यार्थियों को पीएचडी उपाधि प्रदान किए जाने संबंधी पत्र इत्यादि।)

क्रम सं.	शैक्षणिक / शोध क्रियाकलाप	विज्ञान/ अभियांत्रिकी/ कृषि/ चिकित्सा/ पशु-चिकित्सा/ विज्ञान संकाय	भाषा/ मानविकी/ कला/ सामाजिक विज्ञान/ पुस्तकालय/ शिक्षा/ शारीरिक शिक्षा/ वाणिज्य/ प्रबंधन तथा अन्य संबंधित विभाग
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CSR Communication and Tribal Empowerment in Chhattisgarh : A District-Level Study of Dhamtari, Kanker and Bastar

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Abstract :

This paper examines the role of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) communication in supporting tribal empowerment in Chhattisgarh, with a focus on three districts: Dhamtari, Kanker, and Bastar. It explores how communication strategies used within CSR frameworks influence development outcomes in education, healthcare, environment, and livelihoods among tribal populations. The study analyses the use of regionally adapted communication practices, including community-level outreach and local media integration, to improve awareness and participation. Evidence suggests that targeted and culturally contextualised communication plays a significant role in increasing programme acceptance and effectiveness, particularly in areas involving women's collectives and forest-based enterprises. The paper identifies barriers such as linguistic diversity, limited access to communication infrastructure, and cultural disconnects, which continue to affect programme reach and sustainability. Based on the analysis of recent CSR initiatives and policy documents, the paper recommends ways to enhance communication models to improve the responsiveness, accessibility, and impact of CSR interventions in tribal regions of Chhattisgarh.

Keywords : CSR Communication, Tribal Empowerment, Chhattisgarh, Livelihood Development, Inclusive Development, Community Participation.

Introduction :

Chhattisgarh, a state with a significant tribal population, faces persistent socio-economic challenges rooted in historical marginalisation, limited infrastructure, and ecological dependency. As per Census 2011, Scheduled Tribes constitute over 30% of the state's total population, concentrated largely in districts such as Dhamtari, Kanker, and Bastar. These regions, rich in natural resources, are also marked by high levels of poverty, low literacy rates, and inadequate access to health and livelihood services.

In response to these challenges, Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) has emerged as an important vehicle for inclusive development, particularly following the implementation of the Companies Act, 2013, which mandates certain firms to invest in community welfare. In tribal areas, CSR interventions increasingly aim to support education, healthcare, environmental protection, and livelihood generation. However, the success of these interventions is closely tied to the effectiveness of communication strategies employed to engage with local communities.

CSR communication plays a crucial role in creating awareness, ensuring participation, and building trust among tribal populations. In areas with linguistic diversity, cultural complexity, and limited digital penetration, communication must go beyond dissemination to become dialogue-oriented and locally relevant. The design, language, medium, and frequency of communication significantly impact the reach and sustainability of CSR programmes.

This study examines the relationship between CSR communication and tribal empowerment in three tribal-majority districts of Chhattisgarh: Dhamtari, Kanker, and Bastar. It seeks to understand how communication strategies influence the outcomes of CSR initiatives in areas such as education, health, environment, and livelihoods. The research further explores the structural and cultural challenges faced in the communication process and suggests context-specific improvements to enhance effectiveness. In doing so, the study contributes to the broader discourse on development communication and the role of corporate engagement in addressing regional inequalities.

Review of Literature :

Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) has evolved as a strategic mechanism for promoting inclusive development, particularly in regions with socio-economic disparities. The enactment of Section 135 of the Companies Act, 2013 institutionalised CSR obligations in India, requiring qualifying companies to spend a minimum of 2% of their average net profits on socially beneficial activities. This legal mandate has led to a growing body of literature focusing on the nature, scope, and impact of CSR initiatives, especially in underserved regions such as tribal areas.

CSR communication, as a distinct research domain, refers to the methods and strategies

employed by corporations and implementing agencies to disseminate, engage, and build trust with beneficiaries. Du, Bhattacharya, and Sen (2010) argued that transparent and stakeholder-focused communication enhances corporate credibility and increases the perceived legitimacy of CSR efforts. Morsing and Schultz (2006) further proposed the need for two-way symmetric communication models that prioritise dialogue over one-way dissemination, particularly in socially sensitive contexts.

When applied to tribal development, CSR communication requires contextual understanding of language, culture, and social structure. Tripathi and Jha (2018) observed that top-down communication models often fail in tribal regions due to linguistic and cultural disconnects, limiting the impact of even well-funded CSR programmes. In contrast, community-driven communication strategies, including participatory media, vernacular messaging, and local facilitators, have shown positive outcomes in awareness-building and programme ownership (Sarkar, 2020).

Several case studies from Indian tribal regions have highlighted sectoral outcomes of CSR activities in education, health, and environment, but fewer studies focus specifically on how communication mediates these outcomes. For example, Singh (2021) noted that livelihood-oriented CSR projects in forest-based tribal communities performed better when accompanied by consistent, local-language communication and feedback mechanisms. Similarly, Reddy and Bhanumurthy (2019) emphasised that the success of CSR-led water and sanitation initiatives depended largely on sustained behavioural communication campaigns adapted to local realities.

While many CSR impact studies rely on company reports, scholars such as Banerjee (2017) and Ray (2020) have critiqued this approach for lacking community perspectives and often overstating corporate outcomes. Thus, a growing emphasis has emerged on evaluating implementing agency reports and triangulating data with government and independent research findings to ensure objectivity.

The gap this study addresses lies at the intersection of CSR communication and tribal empowerment in the context of Chhattisgarh—a region with dense tribal populations and active CSR implementation. While broader frameworks exist, there is a lack of district-level, communication-specific analysis that examines how CSR messaging influences community participation and programme effectiveness across sectors like education, healthcare, environment, and livelihoods. This study builds on existing theoretical insights while contributing region-specific empirical observations that may inform both academic and policy-oriented discussions.

Methodology :

This study adopts a qualitative, comparative case study approach to examine how Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) communication contributes to tribal empowerment in the districts of Dhamtari, Kanker, and Bastar in Chhattisgarh. The selection of these districts is based on their

significant tribal population, presence of active CSR initiatives, and representation of diverse socio-environmental contexts within the state.

The research relies entirely on secondary data sources. CSR communication practices and sector-specific interventions were analysed through CSR disclosures of relevant companies from the financial years 2019–2023. Instead of depending solely on corporate narratives, greater emphasis was placed on reviewing reports, activity records, and monitoring documents published by implementation partners and civil society organisations involved in programme execution in tribal areas. Government publications, including Census 2011 data, NITI Aayog district development reports, and reports from the Ministry of Tribal Affairs and State CSR Authority, were utilised to establish baseline demographic and socio-economic conditions.

The study also draws from peer-reviewed academic literature to understand theoretical models of CSR communication and its impact on development. Communication strategies were mapped and categorised based on their mode (oral, print, digital), level of localisation, language adaptation, and participatory elements. District-level comparisons were made to identify variations in communication models and their observed influence on awareness, community participation, and beneficiary outcomes—especially among women and forest-dependent tribal groups.

No primary data collection was undertaken. The reliability of secondary data was ensured by triangulating information from at least two independent sources per observation. Data was thematically coded and interpreted to identify patterns, gaps, and insights relevant to CSR communication efficacy in tribal empowerment contexts.

Demographic and Socio-Economic Context :

Chhattisgarh is one of India's most tribal-dominated states, with Scheduled Tribes constituting approximately 30.6% of its total population (Census 2011). The tribal presence is especially concentrated in districts such as Dhamtari, Kanker, and Bastar, which form part of the larger Bastar plateau—an ecologically rich but socio-economically marginalised zone. The communities residing in these regions include major tribal groups such as Gond, Halba, Maria, Muria, and Bhatra, who are predominantly forest-dependent and maintain distinct cultural and linguistic identities.

In **Dhamtari**, tribals make up over 25% of the district's population. While the district has moderate agricultural activity, a large section of the tribal population relies on collection and sale of non-timber forest produce (NTFP), primarily tendu leaves, mahua, and medicinal plants. Literacy among tribal women remains significantly below the state average, and health indicators—particularly maternal and child health—show persistent gaps.

Kanker, located in the central tribal belt of the state, has nearly 55% tribal population. The

district is characterised by high forest cover and seasonal migration due to the limited availability of sustainable livelihoods. Agricultural productivity is low due to rainfed conditions, and forest-based activities are often under-organised. Access to clean drinking water, sanitation, and functional healthcare centres remains uneven across tribal villages.

Bastar, historically one of India's most underdeveloped districts, has a tribal population exceeding 66%. Known for dense forests and complex terrain, the region faces multifaceted development challenges. Health infrastructure is sparse, educational institutions are often inaccessible, and employment opportunities are scarce outside the forest economy. A significant portion of the tribal population in Bastar engages in tamarind collection and lac cultivation, which serve as seasonal income sources but remain vulnerable to market fluctuations and middlemen exploitation.

Across all three districts, tribal livelihoods are closely tied to natural resources and traditional knowledge systems. However, their integration into formal development frameworks—especially through Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) interventions—has been limited by linguistic diversity, socio-economic isolation, and infrastructural constraints. The cumulative effect of these factors has led to persistent disparities in health, education, income, and access to basic services among tribal populations.

This contextual overview highlights the importance of tailored and inclusive CSR communication strategies. Without addressing the ground realities of tribal communities—such as language, mobility, and media access—CSR programmes risk low participation, poor impact, and lack of sustainability. The study therefore places this demographic backdrop at the centre of its analysis to evaluate how communication strategies align with the actual needs and capacities of tribal populations in Chhattisgarh.

Effective communication is central to the success of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives, particularly in tribal regions where socio-cultural dynamics and infrastructural limitations shape how information is accessed and understood. In Chhattisgarh's tribal districts of Dhamtari, Kanker, and Bastar, CSR communication strategies have evolved to address challenges related to language diversity, low literacy, and limited digital penetration.

A key feature of CSR communication in these areas is the use of **offline and community-based methods**, such as village-level meetings, wall paintings, street plays (nukkad natak), and locally organised information campaigns. These channels are not only cost-effective but also culturally accessible. In many programmes, visual aids and oral storytelling formats are used to simplify messages around health, education, sanitation, and livelihoods. Communication through **Self-Help Groups (SHGs)** and community resource persons has also emerged as a reliable strategy, especially for

reaching women and forest-based worker groups engaged in tamarind collection, lac cultivation, and other seasonal livelihoods.

In areas with better connectivity—particularly near semi-urban clusters—**digital communication** has been selectively introduced. This includes WhatsApp-based group coordination for training schedules, awareness videos, and updates related to welfare schemes. However, the reach of such initiatives remains limited due to patchy mobile networks and digital illiteracy, especially among older tribal women.

Language localisation plays a critical role. In many interventions, materials are translated or adapted into regional dialects such as Halbi, Gondi, and Chhattisgarhi. Community radio, where operational, has been used to broadcast programmes on health awareness, forest rights, and educational schemes. In-school activities supported under CSR projects also use context-sensitive content and involve local teachers to improve trust and retention among tribal children.

CSR implementing agencies have also employed **participatory communication models**, wherein beneficiaries are involved in identifying needs, shaping interventions, and giving feedback. This shift from top-down communication to more inclusive dialogue has helped improve programme uptake and retention. In Kanker and Bastar, for instance, women involved in lac and tamarind value chains were more responsive when messages were shared through peers or facilitators from their own community.

Nonetheless, limitations remain. In many areas, communication is still one-directional, with little scope for feedback or adaptation based on local understanding. Monitoring mechanisms for evaluating the effectiveness of communication efforts are often absent or weakly structured.

Overall, CSR communication in tribal Chhattisgarh reflects a growing recognition of the need for culturally grounded, participatory, and multi-modal strategies. The balance between traditional and digital platforms, the emphasis on local language, and the use of peer networks are shaping how tribal communities engage with CSR interventions. The success of these strategies depends not only on message content but on sustained interaction, mutual trust, and responsiveness to local conditions.

CSR Communication Strategies in Tribal Areas :

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Impact of CSR Communication on Empowerment :

CSR communication plays a significant role in shaping the empowerment outcomes of tribal

communities by enabling better awareness, participation, and access to development initiatives. In the districts of Dhamtari, Kanker, and Bastar, targeted communication strategies have contributed to measurable improvements across several social indicators.

Environmental Awareness and Resource Management : CSR-backed campaigns have promoted community-based natural resource management, especially around river rejuvenation and afforestation efforts. Communication strategies have encouraged behavioural shifts in waste disposal and water conservation through village-level sensitisation and participatory drives. The messaging has resulted in increased community ownership of environmental assets.

Educational Outcomes : By simplifying information about school enrolment drives, scholarship eligibility, and nutritional schemes, CSR communication has led to higher enrolment rates, particularly among tribal girls. The use of culturally relevant messaging in local languages has been effective in reducing dropout rates and increasing parental involvement in school activities.

Agricultural Knowledge and Practices : CSR initiatives focusing on agro-based livelihoods have used visual aids and field demonstrations to introduce sustainable practices, such as organic composting and mixed cropping. This has contributed to improved yields and reduced dependency on intermediaries, thereby enhancing economic stability.

Women's Livelihoods and Self-Reliance : Communication targeting tribal women has played a vital role in the formation and strengthening of Self-Help Groups (SHGs), leading to greater financial inclusion. Many women have adopted income-generating activities like tamarind processing and lac cultivation as a direct result of CSR-supported awareness and training campaigns.

Sanitation and Health Behaviour : Cleanliness drives, conducted through interactive methods like street plays and audio announcements, have improved sanitation habits. Communication around hygiene practices and availability of clean drinking water has also influenced behavioural change, particularly in interior villages.

Overall, the impact of CSR communication has been most visible where messages are locally adapted, continuously reinforced, and supported by on-ground facilitation. Empowerment has occurred not just through the provision of services but by enhancing agency, participation, and informed decision-making within tribal communities.

Challenges in CSR Communication :

Despite the growing presence of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives in tribal regions of Chhattisgarh, several challenges continue to hinder the effectiveness of CSR communication. These limitations often reduce the intended impact of programs and restrict meaningful community engagement.

Linguistic and Cultural Gaps : A major barrier is the mismatch between corporate messaging and local linguistic or cultural contexts. Many CSR campaigns use standardized communication formats that fail to resonate with tribal dialects or indigenous knowledge systems, leading to low comprehension and engagement.

Limited Access to Communication Infrastructure : In remote tribal regions, access to communication infrastructure—such as internet connectivity, mobile networks, and print media—is sporadic. This restricts the reach of digital campaigns and online CSR portals, particularly in Bastar and parts of Kanker where digital literacy remains low.

Top-Down Communication Models : Many CSR initiatives still follow a one-way communication model, where information is disseminated without adequate feedback loops. This limits the ability to adapt programs based on local needs and reduces trust among the beneficiaries.

Inadequate Collaboration with Grassroots Facilitators : Poor coordination with local NGOs, community leaders, and tribal panchayats weakens the authenticity and credibility of CSR messages. Without trusted intermediaries, communication efforts are often viewed with skepticism or disinterest.

Insufficient Monitoring and Evaluation : The absence of consistent monitoring frameworks for communication impact makes it difficult to measure outcomes effectively. Feedback mechanisms are either informal or entirely absent, leading to repetitive strategies that may not address emerging challenges.

Short-Term Campaigns and Discontinuity : Many CSR communication efforts are project-based and lack long-term commitment. This results in fragmented messaging, low community retention, and minimal behavioural change.

Addressing these challenges requires adopting participatory communication strategies that prioritize cultural relevance, inclusivity, and sustained dialogue. Integrating local voices into the design and delivery of CSR communication can significantly enhance its effectiveness and long-term impact.

Comparative Analysis: District-Level Observations :

A comparative examination of CSR communication and its empowerment outcomes across Dhamtari, Kanker, and Bastar districts reveals key variations influenced by geography, tribal demographics, local governance, and the nature of CSR implementation.

1. Dhamtari District :

Dhamtari shows relatively higher responsiveness to CSR communication efforts, especially in sectors like agriculture and water conservation. The district's accessibility, better road networks, and proximity to administrative centers have allowed for more consistent communication campaigns.

Tribal women's participation in livelihood programs has increased, often facilitated by community resource centers and self-help groups supported by CSR initiatives.

2. Kanker District :

In Kanker, CSR activities have shown moderate outreach. Programs related to forest-based livelihoods and education have been introduced, but communication efforts are often limited by weaker infrastructure. Despite this, localized media like community radio and engagement with local leaders have improved awareness and participation among tribal communities, particularly in Charama and Bhanupratappur blocks.

3. Bastar District :

Bastar presents the most complex landscape due to its dense forest cover and higher concentration of marginalized tribal populations. While several CSR programs have targeted Bastar—especially in environment and health—communication has faced substantial hurdles due to remoteness and conflict-prone zones. Nevertheless, visual and oral communication methods adapted to tribal contexts have had better resonance in specific clusters.

Observational Insights :

- The effectiveness of CSR communication is positively correlated with infrastructural access and the involvement of local facilitators.
- Districts with stronger NGO or community-based partnerships have experienced more culturally grounded communication and deeper trust.
- Variations also reflect in the empowerment outcomes, with Dhamtari showing better indicators in water and agricultural initiatives, while Bastar exhibits slower but culturally embedded progress.

This district-level comparison underscores the need for region-specific communication frameworks that consider local challenges, strengths, and socio-cultural dynamics to enhance the overall impact of CSR on tribal empowerment.

Conclusion :

This study underscores the critical role of effective Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) communication in fostering tribal empowerment in Chhattisgarh's districts of Dhamtari, Kanker, and Bastar. It reveals that while CSR initiatives have contributed significantly to improvements in education, livelihood, agriculture, environment, and water access, the degree of impact is often influenced by the communication methods adopted. Transparent, inclusive, and culturally responsive communication not only enhances awareness but also ensures deeper engagement and ownership among tribal communities. To maximize long-term social development outcomes, CSR programs must move beyond

compliance-driven communication towards dialogue-based, participatory models that respect local contexts and actively involve the voices of the communities they aim to serve.

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